

2000-2009

The DECADE that changed the world Sexual Evolution

ALL THEORY And Little Practice

As the male torso competes for attention with the female body, urban sexuality is still caught between tradition and modernity

By Parul Dave Mukherji

Recent sex surveys have revealed astounding facts about the changing norms of sexuality that underpin the lifestyle of urban Indians. Consumer freedom, the very basis of advance capitalist economy, has now translated into sexual freedom; the loosening of sexual inhibitions, increasing assertion of desire by women and a more experimental attitude towards one's body. *Dil mange more* has become the growing mantra of not only men but also women. A new vocabulary of discontent has emerged that articulates married couples' disenchantment with the institution of marriage; adultery is no longer a phenomenon that can be brushed under the middle class carpet but a sociological reality to reckon with, which is now being explained as a husband's failure to satisfy his wife's bodily and emotional needs. Pre-marital sex, a taboo until recently, has begun to feature easily in conversations. Can these new mores of sexual freedom be linked with globalisation, with easier flow of information and unprecedented access to the porn culture?

How has the so-called sexual revolution made its presence felt across the urban landscape in public spaces? Earlier, if public

parks were the only space open to couples to snatch some privacy, today the Barista culture has opened up new arena of sociability where "a lot can happen over coffee" between men and women, women and women, as well as men and men. This cosmopolitan culture is fully in line with the Internet exchanges and chat lines that can bring strangers together, sometimes on the basis of their customised sexual preferences. In the new dynamics of friendship in the age of information technology, visual appeal has achieved paramount salience among generations of Internet users, with the Facebook capturing the narcissism of the global age.

Bhupen Khakhar, India's seminal artist, who has painted on homosexuality since the 1980s, would have been elated at the nascent sexual revolution that the revocation of Section 377 appears to have initiated. He was India's first modern artist to not only come out of the closet but proclaim his homosexuality boldly in his paintings. In these paintings, he achieved what irks most people about gays as consenting adults who enter an emotional and tender relationship with each other. Tejal Shah, artist-activist, brings into view layers of complexity in her depiction of lesbian and transsexual relationships. Of course, this kind of new visual



- The Information Technology Act 2000 says distributors of digital pornography could face up to five years in jail.
- In 2006, the law on marital rape changes, making it illegal for the husband to have coercive sex with his wife.
- In 2009, the Delhi High Court decriminalises homosexuality by throwing it out of the ambit of Section 377 of the Indian Penal Code.

Freedom of PROTEST



2001 Gay and lesbian rights activists file a petition asking courts to decriminalise same sex relationships.

2002 Four women poets, Kutty Revati, Salma, Sugirtharani

and Malathy Maithri, are attacked in Tamil Nadu because they write about sex.

2005 Tamil Nadu turns against actor Khushboo who says that men should not expect their wives to

be virgins.

2006 Hindu right-wingers vandalise M.F. Husain's shows protesting his works portraying Hindu goddesses and Bharat Mata in the nude.

2006 Tits Clits and Elephant Dick, a show of nudes and installations by Sanjeev Khandekar with Vaishali Narkar at Mumbai's Jehangir Art Gallery, is censored by the police